frisking the female VVIP guests could not do so for lack of cooperation from the organizers. They probably thought it might bruise the ego of the VVIPs.

‘Organizers meaning ... ?’ Anirudhya asked.

‘The Congress party.’

An orderly brought in steaming filter coffee, with an accompaniment of local sweets.

‘I was certainly unhappy to see the way some party functionaries conducted themselves at the venue. I asked them why the wooden barricades were not made to the specifications provided by the police department. I didn’t get a satisfactory answer. My juniors complained of lack of support from the event organizers whenever any security concern was raised. Security issues were least on their list of their priorities,’ said Raghavan. Anirudhya was making notes fast. But, inside, he wasn’t happy with the outcome. A mere line or two criticizing the Congress party’s attitude didn’t make for a good story. The dailies were full of such reports. Raghavan was talking about security lapses, whereas Anirudhya was looking for material on the killers. The senior IG promised to meet him again.

Next morning Anirudhya visited the Madras bureau again and got a warm welcome from Viswanathan. Tekwani and Shetty were out on an assignment. Viswanathan was following AIADMK (All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam) supremo J. Jayalalithaa’s campaign for the assembly election. After a cup of hot filter coffee, Viswanathan invited Anirudhya along, unless he had prior engagements.

Hanging around with Viswanathan paid dividends at the end of the day when the Madras bureau chief thought of dropping in at the DMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam) party office to get their reaction to media speculations about the party’s sympathetic attitude towards the LTTE. Rajiv Gandhi had earned the wrath of the party ever since he had forced Chandra Shekhar’s minority government in New Delhi to dissolve the DMK’s government in Tamil Nadu and impose President’s Rule in the state. So